

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

FRIDAY 7 AUGUST 2026 · THE WEEKDAY BRIEFING



THE SPINE · THE PREMIUM

THE WORLD

Iran opens a corridor through Hormuz — and a toll booth

THE RABBIT HOLE

Disney's biggest ship now sails from Marina Bay — inside the repeat-cruiser cult

THE LONG READ

Seoul pays ₩4,000 for four photos — the boom the West hasn't clocked

Twelve Desks Source: Wikimedia Commons — Singapore's National Stadium at the Sports Hub, the venue of NDP 2026 (p5). Representative; honestly labelled.

THIS ISSUE

Contents

p3–4 The World — Iran agrees a corridor through Hormuz, and buries a toll no state has ever charged for a strait in the clause

p5 Singapore — the parade returns to the Stadium under a roof; the policy that matters waits two Sundays for the Rally

p6 Property — nine in ten new-launch flats sell out in a supply-starved year, while a state land tender draws a single bid

p7–8 Technology — the best open model on earth ships its weights for free; the one that fits a home rig is still a promise

p9 The Kit — Sony revives its one-body travel camera after nine years, wrapped around a sensor that is nine years old

p10 The Good Life — a new ryokan opens across the water from Miyajima's floating gate, every one of its rooms turned to the sea

p11 Screen & Sound — a billion dollars in six days, and the franchise-worst reviews the record never had to answer

p12–13 The Family Desk — the largest child-brain study finds the lever was never the screen; it was the sleep

p14 The Macro Desk — records on Tuesday, a reversal by Thursday, and the jobs number that lands after this book closes

p15–17 The Rabbit Hole — the cruise a devoted core takes twenty-five times, now home-ported at Marina Bay

p18 Fitness — the weighted walk that undercuts running on injuries and doubles the return of a plain stroll

p19–20 The Diary — a sumo basho whose seats vanish tomorrow, and three new Singapore tables

p21–23 The Long Read — "Life in Four Cuts"

FROM THE DESK

"A cynic is a man who knows the price of everything and the value of nothing."

— Oscar Wilde, *Lady Windermere's Fan* (1892)¹

An issue about premiums, and whether they are worth paying. A toll on the world's oil lane (p3); a record bought on a truce nobody has signed (p14); a cruise at three times a rival's fare (p16); a camera at a nine-year premium for reach (p9); four printed photographs for ₩4,000 in a country where the phone shot is free (p21). Wilde's cynic prices everything and values nothing. This week's subjects keep paying up — the whole question is which of them know the difference.

THE STRIP — AT THURSDAY'S CLOSE

LEVEL	6 AUG
VWRA (All-World)	~\$194.0
US 10-Year	~4.68%
DXY	99.76
USD/SGD	~1.292
Brent	~\$80
Gold (XAU)	~\$4,255
Bitcoin	~\$64.3k

Indicative levels around the 6 Aug close; held where a clean print was unverifiable. July payrolls print tonight. See The Macro Desk (p14).²

THE MERIDIAN INDEX

Days of free passage before Iran means to charge tankers to cross Hormuz: **60** — [p3](#)

States that have ever charged a toll to cross an international strait: **0** — [p3](#)

Share of the air-defence missiles allies sent in 2025 that Ukraine says arrived this year: **a third** — [p4](#)

Drones flying beneath the closed National Stadium roof on Sunday: **300+** — [p5](#)

Singapore's second-quarter growth, per cent: **5.7** — [p5](#)

Bids for the Berlayar Drive land tender: **1** — [p6](#)

Take-up at the year's marquee condo launches, per cent: **up to 94** — [p6](#)

Parameters in the best open-weight model on earth, trillions: **2.8** — [p7](#)

Huawei's share of China's AI-chip market, per cent: **~50** — [p7](#)

Days for Spider-Man to earn its first billion dollars: **6** — [p11](#)

Share of an adolescent's anxiety-to-friendship link that runs through sleep, per cent: **36.3** — [p12](#)

Variance in child wellbeing that digital tech explains, per cent: **0.4** — [p12](#)

Points the Dow shed on Thursday, snapping a record streak: **464** — [p14](#)

Sailings to reach Disney's top loyalty tier: **25** — [p15](#)

Times a Disney cruise costs more than a comparable Carnival one: **~3** — [p16](#)

Fee for a strip of tape on a Disney stateroom door, US dollars: **100** — [p17](#)

Injuries per thousand hours, rucking versus running: **3 vs 18** — [p18](#)

Won for a strip of four printed photos in Seoul: **4,000** — [p21](#)

Korean photo-booth studios that closed in 2024: **611** — [p21](#)

Fried-chicken restaurants in Korea, in thousands: **~40** — [p22](#)

SOURCES 1 Oscar Wilde, *Lady Windermere's Fan* (1892) — Lord Darlington's definition of a cynic ("a man who knows the price of everything and the value of nothing"); frames this issue's throughline, the premium and whether it is worth paying (see The World, p3; The Macro Desk, p14; The Rabbit Hole, p16). 2 Market strip — indicative levels around the 6 Aug 2026 close: VWRA ~\$194.0, US 10Y ~4.68%, DXY 99.76, USD/SGD ~1.292, Brent ~\$80, gold ~\$4,255 (record zone), BTC ~\$64.3k; held where a clean print was unverifiable. US July non-farm payrolls print after this book closes (see p14). Not investment advice. 3 The Meridian Index harvests numbers from this issue, each footnoted to its desk; the sequencing is the commentary.

THE WORLD • THE STRAIT

Iran Draws the Corridor — and a Toll Booth

Tehran says it has agreed the coordinates of a new Hormuz shipping route with Oman. Read past the map to the clause the shipowners are already fighting: a sixty-day grace period, and then a fee to cross a strait no state has ever been allowed to charge for.

The de-escalation arrived with a price tag attached. Iran's foreign ministry said this week that it and Oman had agreed "in principle" on a new commercial corridor through the Strait of Hormuz — coordinates fixed, joint management in drafting — with inbound tankers running through Iranian waters and outbound traffic hugging Oman.¹ The structure is the part that matters: an initial sixty-day arrangement with no charge, and then a transit-fee regime.¹ It is not a reopening. Iran still ties any lasting settlement to the United States lifting its naval blockade, and the whole thing awaits a sign-off from Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei, unseen in public and reported wounded.²

The fee is where a truce becomes a transfer. No country has ever levied a toll for passage through an international strait, and the proposal turned the industry against the deal before a page was signed: leaders of eight owner and operator groups warned

that a charge on Hormuz would harm livelihoods worldwide and set a precedent every choke-point state would notice.³ Washington disputes Tehran's account outright — a US official told the wires any temporary arrangement "would not involve Iranian approval for ships to transit or charges for using the waterway."² Two governments describing one corridor in incompatible terms, and an industry reading the fine print as a bill. Roughly a fifth of the world's seaborne oil passes here; the barrel prices the clause, not the handshake.⁴

60 days

OF FREE PASSAGE IN THE PROPOSED CORRIDOR — AND THEN A TRANSIT FEE, THE FIRST A STATE WOULD EVER CHARGE FOR AN INTERNATIONAL STRAIT, ON THE LANE THAT CARRIES ABOUT A FIFTH OF THE WORLD'S SEABORNE OIL.¹

GULF WAR, MONTH 6

A TOLL, NOT A REOPENING

AWAITING KHAMENEI

NEW YORK — FORTUNE

"SHIPOWNERS ARE OUTRAGED"

The Western business framing leads not on peace but on the invoice. Fortune reports the world's shipping lobby in open revolt: leaders of eight owner groups protesting the fee before it is even signed, on the logic that a charge for passage flows straight to cargo, insurance and the pump. The corridor is treated as settled and the toll as the live fight — the headline is de-escalation, the substance is who pays.³

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

"SOVEREIGN RIGHTS OF BOTH SIDES"

The regional framing reads the same facts as a win for Tehran. Al Jazeera foregrounds that Iran rejected Oman's softer, Malacca-style model of voluntary contributions, insisting each state administer the lanes on its own side, with reopening conditioned on the US ending its blockade. The corridor is not a concession but a codification of control — the strait managed by agreement rather than held by force.²

THE SCEPTIC — THE TOLL HAS NO LEGAL FLOOR

The International Maritime Organization put the objection plainly: "There is no international agreement where tolls can be introduced for transiting international straits. Any such toll will set a dangerous precedent."³ Legal analysts add that a charge would breach the free-passage guarantees of the Law of the Sea, which has no Suez- or Panama-style carve-out for a natural strait. The deal is real when a joint text is published, a Western-allied vessel transits unmolested, and the fee is either dropped or tested — none of which had happened at filing. Watch the water, not the wording.³

SOURCES ¹"Iran says deal with Oman on Strait of Hormuz agreed in principle," Bloomberg, 6 Aug 2026 (coordinates fixed; joint management in drafting; inbound Iranian waters / outbound near Oman; deputy FM Kazem Gharibabadi — 60-day no-fee arrangement, then a transit-fee regime). ²"Hormuz deal close — what's the latest on each side's positions," Al Jazeera, 6 Aug 2026 (reopening conditioned on US lifting the blockade; awaits Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei, reported wounded; "sovereign rights of both sides"; US official denies Iranian approval or charges — via AP). ³"Iran-Oman deal on the Strait of Hormuz — shipowners warn on fees," Fortune, 6 Aug 2026 (eight shipping-lobby groups protesting the fee); IMO spokesperson to Reuters ("no international agreement where tolls can be introduced... a dangerous precedent"); UNCLOS free-passage analysis — PBS NewsHour, 6 Aug 2026. 4 ~½ of seaborne oil transits Hormuz — standard estimate (EIA), as carried in this desk's prior coverage. Framings attributed to their outlets; the fee and casualty claims labelled to source.

THE WORLD · THREE FRONTS

Pledges Made, Interceptors Missing

A record night of missiles over Kyiv against a defence running dry, a stabilisation force for Gaza that exists mostly on paper, and a Lebanon deal being negotiated and bombed in the same week — three fronts where the promise outpaces the delivery.

The deadliest strike on Kyiv this year came overnight into Wednesday: a mass Russian barrage of missiles and drones killed at least seventeen people across the capital region.¹ The number under the toll is the one that governs the war. President Zelensky said allies have delivered only about a third of the air-defence interceptors they supplied over the course of 2025 — the shortfall that turns a ballistic salvo from a survivable event into a lethal one.¹ The maths of the front has inverted: a cheap drone drains a costly interceptor, and the side with the emptier magazine loses the night regardless of who is "winning." Kyiv answered by striking Russian logistics, but the exchange rate on defence is what the casualty count only begins to measure.

Gaza's peace is being assembled the same way — as a set of commitments awaiting the thing itself. Uganda's parliament approved sending troops to the International Stabilisation Force, the roughly 20,000-

strong contingent envisaged under the Trump administration's "Board of Peace" and to be commanded by US Major-General Jasper Jeffers; Morocco has also pledged.² A force with a commander, a mandate and volunteers is not yet a force on the ground. And in the north, negotiators met in Rome to implement the US-brokered June deal between Israel and Lebanon even as a fresh Israeli airstrike hit southern Lebanon, nudging the dollar up on the day — a deal being written and tested in the same forty-eight hours.³

STILL ON THE WIRE

The interceptor gap — Zelensky puts allied air-defence deliveries at about a third of 2025's volume; the shortfall, not the salvo size, is the story.¹

The ISF, on paper — Uganda approves troops, Morocco pledges; a 20,000-strong force with a US commander and, as yet, no deployment.²

Rome — Israel-Lebanon implementation talks proceed under a fresh airstrike; the ceasefire is a work in progress, not a settled fact.³

THE CHATTER — THE ANALYSTS' READ

The through-line drawn across the three fronts this week is the gap between the announcement and the capacity behind it. On Ukraine, defence analysts keep reframing the Kyiv nights as a supply problem — "Ukraine runs low on air defences" rather than "Russia escalates" — because the first is fixable and the second is weather. On Gaza, the sober read is that a stabilisation force is only as real as its first boots and its rules of engagement, neither yet defined. The common lesson: a pledge is cheap, and this is a season thick with pledges.²

THE SCEPTIC — MIND THE ROUND NUMBERS

Handle the figures with the same care as the diplomacy. "A third of the interceptors" is a leader's framing in a fight for more of them, not an audited inventory; a parliamentary vote to send troops is authorisation, not arrival; and an airstrike during talks can be a signal, a spoiler or a coincidence. The honest version of all three is that defences and deals alike are thinner than the headlines suggest — not that any of them has already collapsed. Attribute the claims, and wait for the delivery.³

SOURCES 1 Russian mass strike on Kyiv, night into 6 Aug 2026, ≥17 killed — Just Security "Early Edition," 6 Aug 2026; Zelensky on allied interceptor deliveries at ~⅓ of 2025 volume — same, and CNBC. 2 Uganda's parliament approves ISF deployment (~20,000-strong International Stabilisation Force under the "Board of Peace," US Maj-Gen Jasper Jeffers commanding; Morocco pledge) — NBC News, 6 Aug 2026. 3 Israel-Lebanon implementation talks in Rome on the 26 Jun US-brokered deal; fresh Israeli airstrike in southern Lebanon nudged the dollar intraday — FXStreet, 6 Aug 2026. Casualty and force figures attributed to their sources; troop numbers are authorised, not yet deployed.

SINGAPORE • SG61

A Parade Under a Roof, a Speech in a Fortnight

National Day returns to the National Stadium on Sunday with the country's first indoor drone show and a "Go Beyond" theme. The number that will actually shape a household lands two Sundays later, when the Prime Minister rises for the National Day Rally.

Singapore turns sixty-one on Sunday, and the parade on 9 August is back inside the National Stadium for the first time since 2016 — under the theme "Majulah Singapura, Go Beyond," with more than 2,600 performers and, as the marquee first, an indoor drone light show of over three hundred craft flying beneath the closed roof, billed as the largest indoor special-effects production in the parade's history.¹ The music breaks from the single-theme-song habit, opening with three tracks — Iman Fandi's "Giants," "Sparkle" by Gareth Fernandez and Dru Chen, and Jasmine Sokko's "You'll Be Okay." The eve carries the Prime Minister's National Day Message on Saturday, delivered by Lawrence Wong in English, with the other official languages by his deputies.¹ It is a confident, well-drilled show for a year without a landmark number.

The consequential date is 23 August, when the Prime Minister delivers the National Day Rally — the annual address where housing supply, cost-of-living transfers and the shape of the next few years are

actually set, and where the run-up this week is all anticipation and no text. The economy hands him a tailwind: advance estimates put second-quarter growth at 5.7% year on year, ahead of expectations and led by manufacturing, with the full-year forecast held at 2 to 4%.² The rest of the docket is continuity: the opposition figure Lim Tean, now subject to an arrest warrant after failing to surrender on 3 August to begin a jail term, has his warrant review fixed for 17 August.³ One cloud is literal — the SIIA's 2026 haze outlook is rated red, only its second such warning since 2019, with August and September the danger window.⁴

300+

DRONES FLYING BENEATH THE CLOSED NATIONAL STADIUM ROOF ON SUNDAY — THE PARADE'S FIRST INDOOR DRONE SHOW, THE HEADLINE OF AN OFF-YEAR BUILT AROUND THE VENUE'S RETURN RATHER THAN A ROUND-NUMBER ANNIVERSARY.¹

SG61 • GO BEYOND

RALLY: 23 AUG

HAZE WATCH: RED

THE CHATTER — THE FIREWORKS MAP, AND A BAG POLICY

Two National Day threads have reappeared on r/singapore, and neither is about the parade proper. The first is the perennial hunt for free front-row fireworks without a ticket — the regulars trade the Stadium Riverside Walk, Tanjong Rhu and Kallang Riverside Park, and grumble, as every year, that a closed ballot leaves most of the island watching from a bridge. The second was new: the organisers' initial list of prohibited items drew enough public pushback that the guidelines were eased — a small "new-generation, indoor NDP versus tradition" skirmish that the enclosed venue quietly created.⁵

THE SCEPTIC — THE OFF-YEAR TELL

Notice what is being sold hardest. An indoor drone show is a genuine first, but it is also the headline precisely because SG61 has no Padang, no floating platform and no round anniversary — a competent parade in a year that lacks a hook. Moving the spectacle under an air-conditioned roof buys reliability and loses the open-air texture the parade was built on; whether that is progress or a subtraction is exactly the argument the eased bag policy hints at. The week's real Singapore story is not Sunday's fly-past but the Rally a fortnight on, where a policy has to survive contact with print.

Watch 23 August.

SOURCES ¹ NDP 2026 at the National Stadium (first since 2016; theme "Majulah Singapura, Go Beyond"; first indoor drone show, 300+ craft under the closed roof, billed the largest indoor SFX production in NDP history; 36 artistes, 2,600+ performers; opening tracks "Giants" — Iman Fandi, "Sparkle" — Gareth Fernandez & Dru Chen, "You'll Be Okay" — Jasmine Sokko) — The Smart Local; Time Out Singapore; Tempo. PM's National Day Message, Sat 8 Aug 2026 (PM Lawrence Wong in English; Mandarin — DPM Gan Kim Yong; Malay — Zaqq Mohamad; Tamil — Dinesh Vasu Dash) — Prime Minister's Office, Aug 2026. ² Singapore Q2 2026 advance GDP +5.7% y/y (ahead of ~5.5% consensus, from a revised 6.3% in Q1, led by manufacturing; full-year forecast held 2.0–4.0%) — CNBC/MTI; MAS core & headline inflation 1.5–2.5% for 2026 — MAS Monetary Policy Statement, 27 Jul 2026. ³ Lim Tean warrant-of-arrest review set for 17 Aug 2026 (failed to surrender 3 Aug) — Mothership; Singapore Law Watch. ⁴ SIIA Haze Outlook 2026 rated red (2nd since 2019; Aug–Sep flagged) — SIIA via Mothership; a risk forecast, not a certainty. ⁵ Community read — r/singapore National Day threads (free-fireworks vantage points; ballot gripes); NDP prohibited-items guidance eased after public feedback — The Independent SG; summarised, not fetched live.

PROPERTY • SUPPLY & DEMAND

The Showflats Sell Out; the Land Bank Goes Quiet

Singapore's new-launch condos are clearing at 88 to 94% in a year with roughly a third fewer projects than the last. In the same market, a state land tender drew a single bid. Buyers are paying up and developers are holding back — the premium is moving to the finished flat.

Two halves of the same market are pulling in opposite directions. On the demand side, 2026's launches are selling out: River Green moved about 88% of its 524 units, River Modern took up 93% of 455 at a median around S\$3,229 per square foot, Pinery Residences in Tampines cleared 94% of 588 at S\$2,548, and Tengah Garden Residences is near sold out at S\$2,113.¹ The scarcity is doing the work: this is a supply-crunch year, with roughly seventeen launches, about a third fewer than 2025, so each opening meets pent-up demand and prices up. Buyers, in short, are paying a premium for a completed, launch-fresh home — and getting the queue to prove it.¹

On the supply side, the developers who would replenish that pipeline are notably less eager. The Berlayar Drive government land tender in Telok Blangah closed on 4 August with exactly one bid — a Hong Leong (Intrepid) and GuocoLand joint venture at S\$576.78 million, or S\$1,515 per square foot per plot

ratio, for a 99-year site of about 415 homes.² The lone offer still cleared roughly 4.5% above the top of the state's guide, so the price held; the crowd did not turn up. The next read on appetite is the larger, MRT-fronting New Upper Changi Road plot of about a thousand units, which closes on 1 September.³ And beneath both sits the HDB paradox this desk has tracked: the resale index has now fallen for a second straight quarter even as a record 491 flats resold above a million dollars, with July logging another 27 million-dollar deals against a wave of roughly 13,480 flats reaching their resale eligibility this year.⁴

88–94%

TAKE-UP ACROSS 2026'S MARQUEE CONDO LAUNCHES — IN A YEAR WITH ABOUT A THIRD FEWER PROJECTS THAN 2025. SCARCITY, NOT EXUBERANCE, IS DOING THE PRICING; THE LAND MARKET, MEANWHILE, DREW A SINGLE BID.¹

LAUNCHES SELL OUT

ONE BID FOR THE LAND

GLS: 1 SEP IS THE TEST

THE CHATTER — THE PROPERTY FORUMS

On r/singaporefi and the Stacked and EdgeProp comment threads, the two speeds are being argued as one puzzle: how can showflats sell out while the land market and the HDB index both cool? The consensus the sober posters reach is the honest one — a thin, supply-constrained launch pipeline manufactures its own urgency, and a disciplined developer declining to overpay for a niche plot is a margin decision, not a market verdict. The worry underneath is affordability: at S\$2,000-plus psf in the outside-central regions, the queue is real but so is the stretch.⁵

THE SCEPTIC — SOLD-OUT IS NOT THE SAME AS CHEAP

Resist reading 90% take-up as strength without a footnote. Launches sell out partly because there are so few of them and because developers meter releases to engineer scarcity; a near-sold-out board can sit above prices a buyer will struggle to see grow. And a single bid at Berlayar is not a crack — it cleared above guide, on a small plot under a punishing land-ABSD and seller's-stamp regime, which is rational restraint, not distress. The genuine demand test is New Upper Changi on 1 September: a thin field there, on a thousand-unit MRT plot, would be the signal. Until then, one number is doing two jobs.

SOURCES 1 2026 new-launch take-up — River Green ~88% of 524; River Modern 93% of 455 (median ~S\$3,229 psf); Pinery Residences, Tampines 94% of 588 (S\$2,548 psf); Tengah Garden Residences near sold out (S\$2,113 psf); 2026 a supply-crunch year, ~17 launches, ~30% fewer y/y — Stacked Homes; LovelyHomes, 2026 (take-up figures as reported; verify against developer sales). 2 Berlayar Drive GLS tender closed 4 Aug 2026 with a sole bid — Intrepid Investments (Hong Leong Holdings) / GuocoLand JV, S\$576.78m = S\$1,515 psf ppr; 99-yr LH, ~271,932 sq ft, ~415 units; ~4.5% above the top of URA's S\$1,100–1,450 guide — 99.co; EdgeProp. 3 New Upper Changi Road GLS (~1,000 units) closes 12 noon, 1 Sep 2026 — URA; 99.co. 4 HDB resale index down a 2nd straight quarter in Q2 2026 (first back-to-back fall in ~7 years) beside a record ~491 million-dollar resale flats; July 2026 ~27 million-dollar deals; ~13,480 flats reaching MOP in 2026 (vs 6,970 in 2025) — TheFinance/PropNex; LovelyHomes (figures as reported; verify against HDB). 5 Community read — r/singaporefi; Stacked/EdgeProp comment threads; summarised, not fetched live. Not investment advice.

TECHNOLOGY · THE OPEN FRONTIER

The Best Open Model on Earth Is Free — and Chinese

Moonshot's Kimi K3 shipped its full weights in late July at 2.8 trillion parameters, the largest open-weight model ever released, and independent scoring places it above Claude Opus 4.8. The premium the frontier labs charge for is the thing a Chinese lab just gave away.

The open-weight camp did not close the gap this summer; it crossed the line. Moonshot AI released the full weights of Kimi K3 on 27 July under a Modified-MIT licence — at a claimed 2.8 trillion parameters, the largest open-weight model ever put out — and, more startling than the size, it landed at number four on the independent Artificial Analysis Intelligence Index, scored above Claude Opus 4.8.¹ For a reader who runs models for a living, the significance is not the leaderboard rank but the licence beside it: a downloadable, self-hostable model performing at the level the closed labs meter by the token. It is the summer's clearest sign that the open frontier has stopped trailing and started setting the pace on the metrics that used to justify the subscription.

The hardware politics under it sharpened the same week. Washington reversed course and resumed issuing H20 export licences to China even as its own Bureau of Industry and Security declared that using Huawei's Ascend 910-series chips anywhere in the world violates US export controls — a policy that tries to sell Nvidia silicon into China and criminalise

the domestic alternative in the same breath.² The pressure behind the U-turn is a market share number: Bernstein now puts Huawei at roughly half of China's AI-accelerator market against Nvidia's single digits.² The two stories are one story. A model that trains and serves on domestic hardware and ships its weights to the world is exactly what an export-control regime cannot reach — and Kimi K3 is the proof of concept.¹

2.8T

PARAMETERS IN KIMI K3 — THE LARGEST OPEN-WEIGHT MODEL YET RELEASED, SCORED ABOVE CLAUDE OPUS 4.8 ON THE INDEPENDENT ARTIFICIAL ANALYSIS INDEX, AND FREE TO DOWNLOAD UNDER A MODIFIED-MIT LICENCE.¹

OPEN WEIGHTS, FRONTIER GRADE

MODIFIED-MIT

HUAWEI ~50% OF CHINA

ALSO ON THE WIRE

GLM-5.2 (744B, MIT) and **DeepSeek V4 (1.6T, MIT)** both have weights live now — the two most permissive trillion-scale releases you can serve on-prem today.³

The H20 whiplash — licences resume even as BIS calls using an Ascend 910 anywhere a violation; the policy is at war with itself.²

THE CHATTER — R/LOCALLLAMA

The community's reaction is equal parts triumph and cold sizing-up. On r/LocalLLaMA the "we won" posts about an open model topping a closed frontier one sit next to the sober reply that 2.8 trillion parameters is a data-centre problem, not a desktop one — the model is free the way a cathedral is free to enter and impossible to take home. The most useful thread this week is the hunt for the distilled and dense variants a workstation can actually load, because "open weights you can't run" is a philosophical victory, not a practical one.¹

THE SCEPTIC — A LEADERBOARD IS NOT A LICENCE

Two cautions travel with the headline. First, "above Opus 4.8 on one index" is a single benchmark family, and the field's Goodhart problem is real — a model tuned to the test can top a table it cannot generalise past, and Hacker News is already flagging tool-use loops where Kimi repeats a failed action without re-reading context. Second, "open-weight" and "well-licensed" are different claims: Modified-MIT is permissive, but the frontier the labs are racing to open is littered with carve-outs and territory clauses. Treat a benchmark win as a starting gun, not a finish line — the real test is what an independent evaluator, and your own rig, make of it.¹

SOURCES 1 Kimi K3 (Moonshot AI) — full weights released 27 Jul 2026; Modified-MIT licence; ~2.8T parameters, billed the largest open-weight model to date; #4 on the Artificial Analysis Intelligence Index, scored above Claude Opus 4.8 — MarkTechPost; DeepInfra; Artificial Analysis. Community reaction and tool-use-loop caveat — r/LocalLLaMA; Hacker News (summarised, not fetched live). 2 US resumes H20 export licences to China (early Aug 2026) while BIS declares using Huawei Ascend 910B/910C/910D anywhere a violation of US export controls; Bernstein estimates Huawei ~50% of China's AI-chip market vs Nvidia ~8% — Tom's Hardware, Aug 2026. 3 GLM-5.2 (744B, MIT) and DeepSeek V4 (1.6T, MIT) weights live on Hugging Face — DeepInfra; MarkTechPost. Benchmark figures vendor- and third-party-reported as noted; treated as claims pending independent replication.

THE HOME LAB • WHAT ACTUALLY FITS

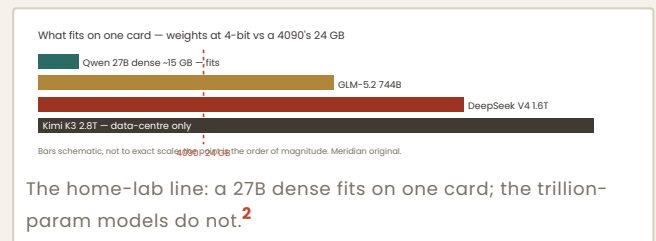
A Trillion Parameters You Can't Load, and the 27B You Can

The models topping the charts are all data-centre creatures — Kimi K3, Qwen3.8-Max, DeepSeek V4. The one that matters for a single-GPU rig is the quiet dense model in the corner, and Alibaba has promised the next one for the week of 10 August. It has promised it before.

The gap between the frontier and the home lab has never been wider. Every headline model of the summer — Kimi K3 at 2.8 trillion parameters, Alibaba's Qwen3.8-Max at 2.4 trillion, DeepSeek V4 at 1.6 trillion, GLM-5.2 at 744 billion — is effectively un-runnable on anything a person owns, needing racks of accelerators just to hold the weights in memory.¹ The number that matters for a single-GPU household is far smaller and far less glamorous: a 27-billion-parameter dense model, which quantised to four-bit lands around 14 to 16 gigabytes and runs comfortably on a 24 GB 4090 — with an eight-bit build sitting on a 32 GB 5090.² Today that sweet spot is held by Qwen3.6-27B, already one of the most-praised single-card local models of the year; the buy-once question is what replaces it.²

Which is the held thread from last week. When Alibaba launched Qwen3.8-Max on 3 August, it committed to open-weighting the model plus a companion Qwen3.8-27B dense checkpoint on Hugging Face and ModelScope "the week of 10 August."³ As this book closes on 7 August, nothing is on Hugging Face and no weight licence is published

— the concrete date is new, the delivery is not. The 27B companion is the one to watch: a dense model at that size is the realistic on-ramp to a frontier-family model that fits on one card, while the 2.4-trillion Max will never live on a desk. For a self-hoster the watch-item is not the parameter count but the licence, still unwritten — the part that decides whether "open" comes with a territory clause.³



~15 GB

A 27-BILLION-PARAMETER MODEL AT FOUR-BIT — SMALL ENOUGH FOR A SINGLE 24 GB CARD, WHILE THE TRILLION-PARAMETER FLAGSHIPS NEED A RACK TO HOLD THE WEIGHTS AT ALL.²

27B IS THE SWEET SPOT

WEIGHTS PROMISED, NOT SHIPPED

LICENCE STILL UNWRITTEN

THE CHATTER — THE SINGLE-CARD CROWD

On r/LocalLLaMA the running joke about Qwen3.8-Max is the serving-cost maths — nobody's home rig loads 2.4 trillion parameters — paired with genuine hope for a distilled or dense variant that fits. The consensus advice for anyone building a buy-once inference box is unchanged: size the rig to the 24-to-32 GB dense class you will actually run daily, not to the flagship you will only ever rent through an API. The 27B tier is where local inference has quietly become good enough to be the default, and a 4090 or 5090 is the pragmatic endpoint.²

THE SCEPTIC — "PROMISED NEXT WEEK" IS A GENRE

Hold the release lightly until it is a download. A preview announcement with a date and no model card, no licence and no independent benchmark is a marketing artefact, and "open weights next week" has become a recurring line rather than a commitment — Qwen3.8-Max was previewed on 3 August with the same promise this desk is still waiting on.³ The honest posture for a home-lab buyer: run the excellent dense model you already have, treat the 10-August date as a hope not a plan, and read the licence before the benchmarks when the weights finally land — because the territory clause, not the leaderboard, is what decides whether you can use it.

SOURCES 1 Summer 2026 flagship open models — Kimi K3 (~2.8T), Qwen3.8-Max (~2.4T), DeepSeek V4 (~1.6T), GLM-5.2 (744B); all effectively data-centre-class — MarkTechPost; DeepInfra. 2 27B dense footprint — ~54 GB BF16 / ~27 GB FP8 / ~14–16 GB at 4-bit; Q4 on a 24 GB 4090, Q8 on a 32 GB 5090; Qwen3.6-27B among the most-praised single-24GB local models of 2026 — YottaLabs; MarkTechPost "best local LLMs on a single 24GB GPU." 3 Qwen3.8-Max launched 3 Aug 2026 (2.4T MoE, 1M context, API-only, \$2/\$6 per M tokens); Alibaba committed to open-weighting Max plus a Qwen3.8-27B dense companion on Hugging Face + ModelScope "the week of 10 Aug"; at filing (7 Aug) nothing on HF and no weight licence published — The Decoder; MarkTechPost; Latent Space. Figures vendor-reported where noted; the release remains unfulfilled at filing.

THE KIT • ONE BODY, EVERYTHING

The Camera That Skips the Bag of Lenses

Nine years after the last one, Sony has revived its bridge camera as the RX10 V — a single body that reaches from 24 to 600mm, ships this month, and costs about US\$2,300. The premium buys reach and never changing a lens. The fine print is the sensor at its heart, which is the same one from 2017.

Sony let the RX10 line sit for almost a decade, and its return is aimed at the buy-once traveller. Unveiled on 9 July and shipping this month at US\$2,299.99 — no Singapore price yet, indicatively past S\$3,150 — it pairs a 20-megapixel stacked one-inch sensor with a 24–600mm f/2.4–4 Zeiss zoom, so one body covers a street scene and a bird on a far branch with no bag of glass.¹ The new parts are the brain and the speed: a BIONZ XR processor with a dedicated AI unit for real-time recognition of people, animals, birds and vehicles; 4K120 ten-bit with S-Log3; up to 30 frames a second blackout-free.¹ For a traveller who wants one camera on a long-haul, the no-lens-swap pitch is the whole appeal.

The clause is under the hood. The RX10 V reuses the same 20-megapixel sensor as the 2017 RX10 IV — DPReview's framing is "a speed, control and video update, not a resolution update."² So the two-thousand-three-hundred dollars buys a faster, cleverer camera around a nine-year-old imaging core, at a price close to a used full-frame body and a zoom, in a world where a phone keeps closing the wide-angle gap. None of that sinks it — the reach and

single-body convenience are real value to the right shooter. It just names the trade: you pay a decade's premium for everything around the sensor, not the sensor.²

24–600mm

THE RX10 V'S SINGLE ZEISS ZOOM — WIDE STREET TO DISTANT WILDLIFE WITH NO LENS CHANGE — AT US\$2,299.99, WRAPPED AROUND THE SAME ONE-INCH SENSOR SONY SHIPPED IN 2017.¹

ONE-BODY TRAVEL

2017 SENSOR CORE

SHIPS AUGUST

IN BRIEF — ALSO WORTH WATCHING

Ricoh GR IV Monochrome — the cult APS-C street compact, now black-and-white only: an AA-filterless ~25.7MP mono sensor, fixed 28mm-equivalent lens, US\$2,199.95 — a ~46% premium over the colour GR IV, for a shooter who commits.³

Xreal One Pro — the AR display glasses drop to a permanent US\$599: 1080p per eye, a 57° field of view, 6DoF, running as a virtual big screen straight off a phone or laptop. A monitor you wear, not a wearable that nags.³

reMarkable — a mini e-notebook is reported for September, slotting under the 7.3-inch colour Paper Pro Move (US\$449); paper-first EDC for the reader who wants ink, not notifications.³

THE CHATTER — THE REVIEWERS' VERDICT

The early read on the RX10 V is warm on the handling and cool on the maths. Reviewers love the autofocus, the 4K120 and the A7-grade controls for travel and wildlife, and call the recognition AF a genuine leap over the 2017 model; the recurring gripe is the price against a nine-year-old sensor, with the honest advice being that this is a camera you buy for the 600mm reach and the one-bag convenience, not for image quality that beats a modern APS-C or full-frame. For the traveller who values never swapping a lens, that is exactly the right trade — for anyone chasing resolution, it isn't.²

THE SCEPTIC — REACH IS NOT RESOLUTION

Keep the two things the RX10 V is selling apart. The reach, the speed and the AI focus are real and, for wildlife and travel, worth paying for. The sensor is not new, and at US\$2,300 the value proposition leans entirely on convenience — a proposition a used full-frame kit undercuts on quality and a modern phone undercuts at the wide end. The buy-once case holds only if the 24-to-600 range is the point of the purchase; if it isn't, the premium is buying a decade of processing around an image core that hasn't moved. Know which camera you're actually paying for.

SOURCES 1 Sony RX10 V — unveiled 9 Jul 2026, shipping Aug 2026, US\$2,299.99 (no SG RRP at filing; indicatively S\$3,150+); 20.1MP stacked 1-inch sensor, 24–600mm f/2.4–4 Zeiss, BIONZ XR + dedicated AI unit (real-time recognition AF — people/animals/birds/insects/vehicles), 4K120 10-bit / S-Log3, 30fps blackout-free (60fps AF/AE tracking), NP-FZ100 battery — Sony/Alpha Universe; B&H; PRNewswire, Jul 2026. 2 "A speed, control and video update, not a resolution update"; reuses the 2017 RX10 IV's 20MP 1-inch sensor — DPReview RX10 V review; PhotoWorkout, Jul 2026. 3 Ricoh GR IV Monochrome (AA-filterless ~25.7MP APS-C mono, fixed 28mm-eq, US\$2,199.95, ~46% premium over the colour GR IV) — Ricoh Imaging; DPReview. Xreal One Pro price cut to US\$599 (1080p/eye, 57° FOV, 6DoF) — Tom's Hardware; Xreal. reMarkable mini e-notebook reported for Sept, under the Paper Pro Move (US\$449, 7.3-inch colour) — Good e-Reader. Prices as listed; SG pricing/availability to confirm.

THE GOOD LIFE · THE ESCAPE

A Ryokan That Watches the Floating Torii

Hoshino's next KAI onsen house opens this summer across the water from Miyajima's great vermilion gate — fifty-four rooms, every one facing the sea, and a bath reviving a method the region had nearly forgotten.

The setting is the whole pitch. KAI Miyajima, the newest house in Hoshino Resorts' onsen-ryokan brand, opens in summer 2026 at Miyajimaguchi in Hiroshima — the mainland shore that looks straight across the strait at the great vermilion torii of Itsukushima Shrine, which appears to float on the tide.¹ All fifty-four rooms face the water: the "Umigiri," or sea-fog, rooms are named for the mist that forms over the Seto Inland Sea, with gradated-blue curtains that draw back to frame Miyajima in the window.¹ The wellness hook is the one this reader will notice — the house revives the "Setouchi ancient sauna," a regional steam method, in a bath built to feel like being immersed in the sea.² It is Hoshino's first property in Hiroshima: a new ryokan with one of Japan's most photographed views in every room.

Read it against what KAI does and doesn't promise. This is accessible luxury with real craft — Setouchi textiles, a kaiseki table, the choreographed bath-and-dinner rhythm standardised across two dozen houses — not the hushed, one-of-one independent ryokan a purist chases. The premium is for reliability and a view, not singularity, and that is a fair trade for a family that wants the floating torii at dawn without

gambling on an unknown inn.² One caveat in the fine print: "summer 2026" is not yet a date and rates are unpublished, so this is a property to watch and pre-plan, not to book to the day.¹

54

GUEST ROOMS AT KAI MIYAJIMA, EVERY ONE FACING THE SETO INLAND SEA AND THE FLOATING TORII ACROSS IT — A NEW RYOKAN BUILT ENTIRELY AROUND A VIEW, OPENING SUMMER 2026 (DATE AND RATES STILL TO FIRM).¹

A brand-new ryokan with one of Japan's most photographed views built into every room.

OPENS SUMMER 2026

SETOUCHI ANCIENT SAUNA

DATE & RATES TBC

STILL ON THE SHELF — AUDIO & OBJECTS

Meze Audio ARTA — a ~US\$6,000 flagship planar-magnetic headphone shown at High End 2026; the aspirational end of the desk, and a true buy-once object.³

Klipsch Atlas HP-3 — Klipsch's first over-ear headphones in a decade, the flagship of a new Atlas line; a comeback worth an audition.³

On the wrist — the DOXA SUB "Army" × Hodinkee stays the week's watch talking point; noted, not led.³

THE CHATTER — THE RYOKAN FORUMS

On the ryokan-enthusiast boards the KAI houses draw a familiar split. The admirers value what KAI Miyajima offers a Japan-loving family — a spectacular, reliable, English-friendly stay with the region's crafts and a serious bath, in a setting that would otherwise mean gambling on a tiny inn. The purists call the polished KAI format "onsen-lite," hospitality for the international trade rather than the owner-run ryokan they prize. For a single night with the floating torii at dawn, the reliable version is not the lesser choice — it is the point.²

THE SCEPTIC — THE THIRD HOSHINO IN A FORTNIGHT

Two caveats. First, this desk has now flagged a Hoshino property three times in short order — KAI Matsumoto's reopening, its Italian table, now KAI Miyajima — and a brand can start to feel like a beat; read this as "a genuinely new house in a singular setting," not a standing endorsement of the group. Second, an unopened hotel is a promise: a date that isn't set, rates unpublished, a view rendered in a press image. Log it, plan around it, and judge it when a real guest has actually slept there.

SOURCES ¹ Hoshino Resorts KAI Miyajima — opening summer 2026 at Miyajimaguchi, Hatsukaichi City, Hiroshima; 54 all-ocean-view rooms ("Umigiri"/sea-fog rooms) facing the Great Torii of Itsukushima across the Seto Inland Sea; Hoshino's first Hiroshima property; opening date and nightly rates not yet published — Hoshino Resorts newsroom & press center ("KAI Miyajima Unveils First Look at its Umigiri Rooms"); Journal des Palaces, 2025–26. ² The revived "Setouchi ancient sauna" bathing method and KAI's standard bath-and-kaiseki format; ryokan-enthusiast "onsen-lite" critique — Hoshino press materials; SELECTED ONSEN RYOKAN and ryokan-enthusiast roundups (summarised, not fetched live). Continuity: KAI Matsumoto reopening and Italian dinner covered in Nos. 63–64 — a one-line callback, not re-covered. ³ Audio & object shelf — Meze Audio ARTA (~US\$6,000 flagship planar, shown at High End 2026, Vienna); Klipsch Atlas HP-3 (first Klipsch over-ears in a decade) — ecoustics; Gear Patrol, 2026. DOXA SUB "Army" × Hodinkee covered in No. 64 — noted, not re-led. Not investment advice.

SCREEN & SOUND · THE FORTNIGHT

A Billion in Six Days, and Then the Real Test

Spider-Man crossed a billion dollars faster than almost any film ever made — a premium the marketing machine pre-sold before a single review landed. The number that will actually measure it is next weekend's drop. Meanwhile the album calendar fills: three releases in a fortnight, and the reviews, unlike the receipts, aren't in.

The receipt is historic and mostly behind us. *Spider-Man: Brand New Day*, which took the biggest domestic opening ever a week ago, crossed a billion dollars worldwide on 4 August — its sixth day, the second-fastest to the mark in history, a day off *Avengers: Endgame*'s record.¹ What that billion measures is scale and marketing: a franchise, a brand, and demand pre-sold so thoroughly that the film's franchise-low reviews never touched the gross. The number that measures the movie rather than the machine is the one this book cannot yet print — the second-weekend hold, which lands on 8–9 August, after we close.¹ A record opening guarantees a steep fall; whether the fall is merely steep or a collapse is the honest test of what audiences, not the pre-sale, actually made of it.

The music desk offers a cleaner run of promises. Ravyn Lenae released her third album, *Blue Island*, today — a deliberate pop pivot, executive-produced by Dahi, drawing a split verdict on arrival (*The Line of Best Fit* hears "refreshing sonic experimentation"; *Slant* finds it "too hesitant to commit").² It opens a dense fortnight: Phoebe Bridgers releases *Lost*

Weekend on 14 August, her first solo album since *Punisher* in 2020, and Weezer's *The Gold Album* follows on 21 August.³ Three records in fourteen days, and only the first has a verdict — the others are still the pre-release argument between fans who hear growth and skeptics who hear a retread: loud anticipation, no receipts yet.³

\$1B / 6 days

HOW FAST *SPIDER-MAN: BRAND NEW DAY* REACHED A BILLION — THE SECOND-FASTEST EVER — ON THE BACK OF THE BIGGEST OPENING IN HISTORY AND THE WEAKEST REVIEWS OF ITS FRANCHISE.¹

RECORDS, FRONT-LOADED

THE DROP IS THE TEST

THREE ALBUMS, 14 DAYS

ALSO CUED UP

KATSEYE — WILD (EP), 14 Aug — the pop counterweight sharing Bridgers's Friday; lead single "Pinky Up."³

New Music Friday — today's slate also carries Karol G and Sam Smith releases; a heavy first Friday of the month.²

Streaming — HBO Max's DC series *Lanterns* (Kyle Chandler, Aaron Pierre) premieres 12 Aug; date and platform worth a check before you set a reminder.³

THE CHATTER — RECORDS, BUT FRONT-LOADED

On r/boxoffice the framing is unanimous and unsentimental: a \$360-million opening all but guarantees a brutal fall multiplier, so the interesting number was never the billion — it was always the second weekend. The fan reaction stays euphoric (a franchise-record audience score, big cheers for the cameos), which is exactly why the critical shrug is the debate: the reasonable-middle take is that this is a crowd-pleasing table-setter critics grade against ambition and audiences grade against a Saturday night. The box office only ever measured one of those.¹

THE SCEPTIC — KEEP THE LEDGERS APART

Do not let "biggest ever" quietly become "best." A record opening measures brand, marketing and pent-up demand; a franchise-low review score with named complaints about pacing and cameo-stuffing is real signal, not sour grapes, and the two describe different things about the same weekend. On the music side, resist the hype cycle in the other direction: a released single is not a released album, and no review of Bridgers or Weezer can exist until the records do. Grade the receipts and the reviews on separate pages — the confusion between them is the whole business model.

SOURCES ¹ *Spider-Man: Brand New Day* crossed US\$1B worldwide on 4 Aug 2026 (its 6th day, 2nd-fastest ever, one day off *Endgame*'s record); biggest domestic opening in history (~\$360M) off a ~\$927M global bow; 2nd weekend (8–9 Aug) not yet reported at filing; franchise-low reviews — *Forbes*; *Deadline*; *Variety*, Aug 2026 (continuity: opening + reviews covered in No. 64, not re-led). ² Ravyn Lenae, *Blue Island* (rel. 7 Aug 2026, her 3rd album, exec-prod. Dahi; mixed reviews — *The Line of Best Fit*; *Slant*); *New Music Friday* 7 Aug also carries Karol G, Sam Smith — *DK Network/Release Radar*. ³ Phoebe Bridgers, *Lost Weekend* (14 Aug 2026, first solo LP since *Punisher*, 2020); Weezer, *The Gold Album* (21 Aug); KATSEYE, *WILD EP* (14 Aug); HBO Max *Lanterns* premieres 12 Aug (date/platform to verify) — *Variety*; *Rolling Stone*; *Tom's Guide*. Reviews—pending items flagged as such.

THE FAMILY DESK · THE REAL LEVER

It Was Never the Screen. It Was the Sleep.

A new analysis of the largest child-brain study in the world finds that among the things a parent can actually change, sleep — not screen time — is the strongest thread between how a ten-to-thirteen-year-old feels and how she does at school and with friends. The highest-yield rule in the house is a bedtime, not an app.

The most useful parenting result of the summer reframes the whole argument. A team led from UC Davis, publishing in *Psychological Medicine* and drawing on the ABCD study — the largest study of the developing child brain in the United States, following children aged ten to thirteen — tested four levers a family controls: sleep, screen time, physical activity and diet.¹ Sleep was the strongest mediator by a distance between a child's mental-health symptoms and her real-world outcomes. It accounted for about 18.5% of the link between depression and lower grades, 36.3% of the link for anxiety, and 8.3% for the more serious psychotic-like experiences; screen time mattered, but came second.¹ The translation for a parent of an eleven-year-old is blunt and freeing: the single highest-return intervention is not a screen-time dashboard, it is protecting sleep — the device out of the bedroom, and a firm stop half an hour to an hour before lights-out.¹

A second 2026 paper, in the *Nature*-portfolio *Humanities & Social Sciences Communications*, points the same way from the other side: where heavy screen use tracks worse mental health in children, it does so largely through displaced sleep and movement — the screen bites by eating the bedtime, not by some separate magic.² That is the quietly optimistic reading of a genre usually sold as alarm. The lever most parents reach for — counting minutes — is aimed at the symptom, while the lever that works, guarding the sleep those minutes were stealing, sits one step behind it. As general guidance, not medical advice: win the bedtime, and much of the screen problem is already solved.

36.3%

OF THE LINK BETWEEN AN ADOLESCENT'S ANXIETY AND HER SOCIAL FUNCTIONING RAN THROUGH SLEEP — THE STRONGEST OF FOUR LIFESTYLE LEVERS TESTED IN THE LARGEST US CHILD-BRAIN STUDY, AHEAD OF SCREEN TIME.¹

SLEEP > SCREENS

BEDROOM, NOT THE APP

NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

THE CHATTER — THE EVIDENCE-MINDED PARENTS

On r/ScienceBasedParenting and the parenting boards, the line that has taken hold this cycle is a de-escalation: stop treating "number of minutes" as the variable and start treating the timing — screens near bedtime remain the clear, repeated harm — as the thing to defend. A widely-shared CNN piece this summer framed the bedroom as the "high-yield" zone: charge the devices outside it, no screens for the last half-hour. Locally the same instinct runs through Singapore's Screen Smart From The Start push and the health ministry's under-two-hours guidance for this age. The consensus is unglamorous and correct: protect the sleep, and stop litigating the minutes.³

THE SCEPTIC — DON'T OVERSELL ONE STUDY EITHER

Keep the humility the data demands. These are mediation analyses of observational cohorts — they show sleep carrying much of the association, not that fixing sleep fixes grades, and healthy-user effects almost certainly flatter the picture. The larger caution comes from Amy Orben and Andrew Przybylski's specification-curve work across hundreds of thousands of children: digital technology explains at most about 0.4% of the variance in wellbeing, an effect they memorably size as "comparable to wearing glasses," and self-reported screen figures are unreliable enough to inflate the numbers everyone quotes.⁴ Read the new result as "guard the sleep," not "screens are ruining her" — the honest posture holds both truths at once.

SOURCES ¹ UC Davis-led analysis, "Mediating effects of healthy lifestyle factors on associations between mental health and functional outcomes in early adolescence," *Psychological Medicine* (Cambridge), ~4 Aug 2026; ABCD Study cohort, children aged 10–13; sleep the strongest of four lifestyle mediators (screen time, physical activity, diet), accounting for ~18.5% of the depression–grades link, 36.3% for anxiety, 8.3% for psychotic-like experiences — Cambridge Core; UC Davis Health release; News-Medical. Figures as reported; n and bands verify-on-primary. ² Screen time linked to worse child mental health largely through displaced sleep and physical activity (parallel mediators) — *Humanities & Social Sciences Communications* (Nature portfolio), 2026. ³ Community/clinical read — r/ScienceBasedParenting; CNN, 2 Jul 2026 ("high-yield" bedroom zone); Singapore "Screen Smart From The Start" (May 2026) and MOH <2h/day guidance for ages 7–12 (excl. schoolwork) — summarised, not fetched live. ⁴ Orben & Przybylski, specification-curve analyses (n=355,000; digital tech <~0.4% of wellbeing variance, "comparable to wearing glasses"; self-report unreliability) — *Psychological Science*/*Nature Human Behaviour*. General guidance, not medical advice.

THE TWEEN YEARS · FROM STUDY TO PRACTICE

A Bedtime Is a Policy You Can Actually Enforce

If sleep is the lever, the useful question is mechanical: what does defending an eleven-year-old's sleep look like on a Tuesday night? The research points to a handful of boring, robust moves — and away from the one number everyone keeps arguing about.

Turn the finding into a household routine and it becomes unglamorous in the best way. An eleven-year-old needs roughly nine to eleven hours of sleep, and the two things that most reliably steal them are a screen in the bedroom and a bedtime that drifts later on a phone's schedule rather than a parent's.¹ The mechanism paper is the permission slip: because screens appear to harm mostly by displacing sleep and movement, a family that fixes the sleep has addressed the largest share of the risk without policing every minute of the day.² The practical stack is short — a consistent lights-out, the device charging outside the bedroom overnight, and a screens-off buffer of thirty to sixty minutes before sleep — and it is enforceable in a way a daily minute-count never is, because it is a place and a time rather than a running negotiation.¹

The other half of the job is resisting the noise. Back-to-school is peak season for the anxiety economy — commissioned "how many nights of sleep parents lose worrying about screens" surveys, engineered to be reprinted, that dress marketing as research.³ The paediatric mainstream has been moving the other way, de-emphasising a fixed minute limit in favour of content, timing and company; the sleep result slots

neatly into that shift.³ The through-line for the optimising parent — general guidance, not medical advice — is to distrust any single number that promises to settle a parenting question by itself, whether a survey's alarming figure, a ban's target, or this study's tidy percentages. Guard the sleep, watch the content and company, and treat the rest as the negotiable it is.²

9–11h

THE SLEEP AN ELEVEN-YEAR-OLD NEEDS — AND THE QUANTITY A BEDROOM SCREEN AND A DRIFTING BEDTIME MOST RELIABLY ERODE. THE FIX IS A PLACE AND A TIME, NOT A MINUTE-COUNT.¹

ENFORCE A PLACE & TIME

DISTRUST THE SINGLE NUMBER

NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

THE DO-THIS FILE

Charge it out of the room — the device sleeps in the kitchen; the single highest-yield rule, and the least negotiable.¹

A 30–60 minute buffer — screens off before lights-out; the timing, not the total, is where the harm concentrates.²

Ignore the survey cycle — a commissioned parental-anxiety poll is a marketing genre; quoting its numbers as fact is how cooling science keeps generating heat.³

THE CHATTER — THE OPTIMISER'S READ

The evidence-minded parenting communities have converged on a line that would have sounded heretical two years ago: stop optimising the minutes and start optimising the sleep, the content and the company. The "moderate use beats none" findings get cited as permission to relax about supervised daytime use — not as a licence for the algorithmic firehose after dark. The recurring warning is the one this desk keeps making: the commissioned anxiety survey is a genre, and treating its headline as a finding is how a de-escalating evidence base still produces a hot news cycle.³

THE SCEPTIC — AN AVERAGE, NOT A PRESCRIPTION

Don't over-read even the good study. "Sleep mediates 36% of the anxiety link" is a population average across tens of thousands of children, not a dose — a calm, well-rested eleven-year-old needs no intervention, and a mediation share is not a promise that an extra hour buys a grade. The boring takeaways survive every caveat: protect sleep, keep screens out of the bedroom and off before bed, watch what and with whom, and hold any single number at arm's length.²

SOURCES 1 Sleep needs for early adolescents (~9–11h); bedroom screens and a drifting bedtime as the primary thieves; enforceable "place and time" routine (device charges outside the room, 30–60 min screens-off buffer) — American Academy of Sleep Medicine / AAP sleep guidance, as summarised in the UC Davis release, Aug 2026 (see p12). 2 Screens harm largely via displaced sleep/movement — *Humanities & Social Sciences Communications* (Nature portfolio), 2026 (p12). 3 The commissioned "parental anxiety" survey genre (back-to-school PR dressed as research); paediatric shift away from a fixed minute limit toward content/timing/company — Talker Research-style commissioned polls, labelled as such; AAP digital-media guidance (Jan 2026). General guidance, not medical advice.

THE MACRO DESK • THE TURN

The Relief Trade Runs Out of Road

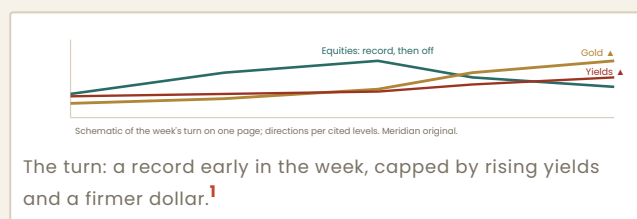
Records on Tuesday, a reversal by Thursday. Yields rose, the dollar firmed and oil bounced, and the Dow's record streak snapped — all before the one number that could settle it lands tonight. Gold, at a record, is charging the highest premium of all.

VWRA ~\$194.0	US 10Y ~4.68% ▲	DXY 99.76 ▲	BRENT ~\$80 ▲	GOLD ~\$4,255 ▲	BITCOIN ~\$64.3k
------------------	--------------------	----------------	------------------	--------------------	---------------------

The week ran the relief trade forward and then in reverse. Early on, the prospect of a Hormuz de-escalation kept the war premium out of oil and let equities set records — the S&P 500 closed near an all-time high of 7,710, VWRA just under its own.¹ By Thursday the tape turned: yields ground back toward their 2026 highs around 4.7%, the dollar firmed while holding below 100, and oil bounced on fresh Gulf and Red Sea headlines — enough to knock the Dow down 464 points and snap a five-session record streak.¹ Under the whipsaw sits one force: a Fed that held at 3.50–3.75% on a hawkish 9–3 vote in which the three dissents wanted a hike. The market is unwinding a hike premium, not pricing an easing cycle, which leaves the whole chain two-sided.²

Gold is charging the steepest premium of all. Bullion printed a record in the mid-\$4,200s — a haven bid feeding on the soft dollar and the hope of easier real yields — even as the ten-year insists the easing may not arrive.¹ For the four instruments this desk tracks, the read follows the regime: an all-world book rode

the records but is capped by rising real yields; global bonds firm at the margin yet stay hemmed in near 4.7%, cushioning less than usual; gold is the standout, pricing a cut the Fed has not promised; and bitcoin is the laggard, around \$64k and down since January, again failing the digital-gold role its boosters assign it.³ Market explanation, not advice — and the number that could ratify or break it, the July jobs report, prints tonight, after this book closes.²



-464

POINTS ON THE DOW ON THURSDAY, SNAPPING A FIVE-DAY RUN OF RECORDS AS YIELDS ROSE AND THE DOLLAR FIRMED — THE RELIEF TRADE RUNNING OUT OF ROAD BEFORE TONIGHT'S JOBS PRINT.¹

RISK-OFF WOBBLE

HIGHER-FOR-LONGER

DOLLAR BID

THE CHATTER — WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

The one-line read: a rally to hold with a hand on the exit. An all-world equity book is doing what it should near record highs, but the bond leg is the catch — with the ten-year pinned near 4.7% by a hawkish-hold Fed, bonds are cushioning less than a diversified holder would like. Gold is pricing an easing the Fed has not delivered and looks stretched on it; bitcoin keeps disappointing the people who called it a hedge. The records lean on a de-escalation nobody has signed and a jobs print nobody has seen. Not a buy or sell call — the read on the four, as it stands tonight.³

THE SCEPTIC — "A LOST YEAR TAKING SHAPE FOR GOLD"

Bank of America's commodity desk is the useful dissent to the record-chasing. Even holding a long-run \$5,000 target, Michael Widmer argues the run into early 2026 was stretched enough that the correction should last far longer than it has — carving a lower high near \$4,325–4,500 before selling resumes into late 2026.⁴ Pair it with bitcoin's double-digit fall since January and net ETF outflows: a rally built on an unsigned truce and a stretched haven reprices fast if the clause it ignores — or tonight's payrolls — turns out to matter. Forecasts are forecasts, not a buy or sell call.⁴

SOURCES ¹ Market levels around the 6 Aug 2026 US session (indicative; held where a clean print was unverifiable): S&P 500 record close ~7,710 then off; Dow ~464 pts / -0.85%, snapping a 5-day record streak; VWRA ~\$194.0 (near its 52-wk high ~\$195); US 10Y ~4.6–4.7% (toward 2026 highs); DXV 99.76 (sub-100, firming); Brent ~\$80 (bounced on Gulf/Red Sea headlines); gold record in the low-to-mid \$4,200s — Yahoo Finance; CNBC; TradingEconomics; Kitco; stockanalysis. USD/SGD ~1.29, USD/JPY ~157.8 held. ² FOMC held 3.50–3.75% (hawkish 9–3, three dissents favouring a 25bp hike); next meeting 15–16 Sep; ADP July private payrolls +44k (a miss); BLS non-farm payrolls for July due Fri 7 Aug 8:30am ET (~8:30pm SGT), after this book closes (consensus ~+85k, unemployment 4.2%) — CNBC; Federal Reserve; Tech Times. ³ Bitcoin ~\$64k, down since January, net ETF outflows — Fortune; CoinDesk. ⁴ BofA / Michael Widmer, "a lost year taking shape for gold" (lower high ~\$4,325–4,500, correction far from over; \$5,000 long-run target) — TheStreet; Yahoo Finance. Market explanation and education, NOT investment advice; forecasts flagged as forecasts; no level fabricated — unverifiable prints held.

THE RABBIT HOLE • THE INVITATION

The Cruise You Take Twenty-Five Times

Most people take a cruise once. A devoted core takes the Disney one again and again — chasing a loyalty tier that tops out at twenty-five sailings, decorating stateroom doors, and exchanging gifts with strangers at sea. And this year, the whole global hobby docked in Singapore.

Disney Cruise Line is not really a holiday; for its core it is a hobby with a fleet. Eight ships, a wall of intellectual property, and a loyalty ladder called the Castaway Club that sorts members not by nights but by cruises completed — Silver at one, Gold at five, Platinum at ten, and, since May 2023, Pearl at twenty-five or more.¹ A tier that only exists because enough people sail that often to justify it tells you what kind of fanbase this is. The archetype is visible in its media: the leading fan podcast, DCL Duo, has run past 650 episodes and a million downloads, hosted by two "Pearl Castaways" with thirty-five-plus sailings each.² These are people who do not go on a Disney cruise so much as keep going, and the going is the hobby.

This year the whole thing sailed to Singapore's doorstep. The Disney Adventure — the largest ship in the fleet at roughly 208,000 gross tons and about six thousand guests, and the line's only Global-class vessel, built on the hull Genting's collapsed shipyard left behind — became Disney Cruise Line's first-ever Asia home-ported ship, making its maiden voyage from Marina Bay Cruise Centre on 10 March 2026 after a delay from a planned December debut.³ It is contracted to home-port here for at least five years, running three- and four-night "cruise to nowhere" sailings — two sea days, no ports — priced from about US\$958 for two on a three-night.³ A subculture that used to require a flight to Florida now boards a fifteen-minute taxi from town. What the next two pages descend into: the rooms where the devotees argue, the economy of the premium they pay, and the rituals — fish extenders, door magnets, a serving

team that follows you to dinner — that make a cruise into a calendar.

25+

COMPLETED SAILINGS TO REACH PEARL, THE TOP CASTAWAY CLUB TIER — A LOYALTY RUNG THAT EXISTS ONLY BECAUSE A DEVOTED CORE CRUISES DISNEY THAT MANY TIMES.¹

8 SHIPS

NOW HOME-PORTED IN SG

3-4 NIGHT CRUISES TO NOWHERE

THE FIRST NINETY DAYS — AN HONEST PATH IN

Lurk first — DISboards' Disney Cruise Line forum for depth; the r/DisneyCruise subreddit for fast newcomer questions.⁴

Right-size it — a 3-4 night on the classic Magic or Wonder, or locally the Adventure from Marina Bay (from ~US\$958 for two), is the low-commitment entry.³

Budget past the fare — add gratuities (~US\$14.50 pp/night), adult dining (Palo US\$55pp), a cabana if you splurge, and fish-extender supplies if you join a group.⁵

Learn the meta early — before your first cruise ends, buy a Placeholder: US\$250 onboard for 10% off a future booking within 24 months. It is how repeaters compound.⁵

THE GATEWAY — HOW PEOPLE FALL IN

The community's account of the hook is consistent, and it is rarely the destination — the flagship sailings barely stop anywhere. It is the ship as a self-contained world for a child, the kids' clubs a parent can hand a nervous seven-year-old without guilt, and the small, engineered rituals that turn a first cruise into a second booking: the character breakfast, the sail-away party, the serving team that learns your daughter's name by night two. The Castaway Club ladder does the rest. Once you are Silver, the next tier is a reason to book again, and the line has built its entire economy on the fact that, for the right family, once is never once.²

SOURCES 1 Castaway Club loyalty tiers by cruises completed — Silver (1), Gold (5), Platinum (10), Pearl (25+, launched 1 May 2023); perks scale with early-booking access — The Points Guy; Disney Cruise Line Blog. 2 DCL Duo podcast — 650+ episodes, 1.1M+ downloads, hosts are "Pearl Castaways" (35+ sailings each) — dclduo.com; Rephonic. 3 Disney Adventure — DCL's first Asia home-ported ship; maiden voyage 10 Mar 2026 from Marina Bay Cruise Centre (delayed from a planned Dec 2025 debut); ~208,000 GT (largest in fleet), ~6,000 guests, only Global-class ship (former "Global Dream" hull); 5-year Singapore home-port; 3- and 4-night cruise-to-nowhere sailings from ~US\$958 for two (3-night) — Disney Parks Blog; Travel Weekly Asia; singaporedisneycruise.com; The Points Guy. 4 Community — DISboards Disney Cruise Line forum; r/DisneyCruise (live subscriber count not verified for print) — disboards.com; reddit. 5 Gratuities ~US\$14.50 pp/night; Palo US\$55pp; Placeholder US\$250 onboard for 10% off within 24 months — EverythingMouse; MagicGuides. Prices as reported.

THE RABBIT HOLE · THE COMMUNITY & THE PREMIUM

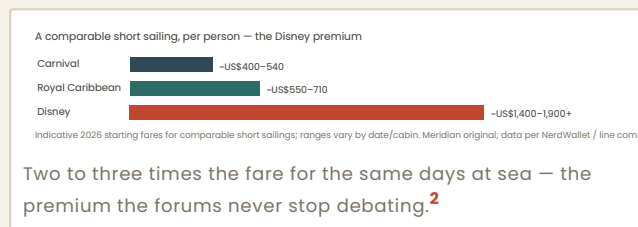
Where They Argue, and What They Pay

The rooms have distinct tempers, and the numbers are the running fight in all of them: a Disney sailing costs roughly two to three times a comparable one on Royal Caribbean or Carnival, and the community has spent fifteen years arguing about whether the last fifteen per cent is worth the first hundred.

The geography of the hobby is clear. DISboards — "the DIS" — is the veteran forum and the institutional memory, earnest and rules-lawyering, where fish-extender groups and cabin exchanges were historically organised.¹ The r/DisneyCruise subreddit is the fast, newcomer-heavy front door for first-cruise questions and money-saving hacks. On top sits a creator economy: DCL Duo for the podcast end, Scott Sanders' Disney Cruise Line Blog running since 2012 as the news wire, DCL Fan as the planning encyclopedia, and Disney Tourist Blog as the sceptical voice.¹ Below it all, Facebook sailing-date groups are where the gift and magnet exchanges actually happen.¹

What the rooms argue about is the premium, and it is real. A seven-night Disney sailing averages roughly US\$1,730 to \$2,750 a person; a comparable Royal Caribbean fare can start near US\$550, Carnival lower still — Disney runs two to three times the price for a comparable cabin.² The onboard spend layers on: adult dining at Palo runs US\$55 a head after last

year's increase, Remy's dinner US\$145, and a private cabana lands between about US\$523 and \$1,375 for the day.³ The honest question is not whether Disney is expensive — it plainly is — but what the premium buys: kids' clubs at no charge, a serving team that follows you, the IP, and a machine engineered so a family never has to think. Whether that is worth it is the fifteen-year argument, unsettled.⁴



~2-3×

WHAT A DISNEY SAILING COSTS AGAINST A COMPARABLE ROYAL CARIBBEAN OR CARNIVAL ONE — THE PREMIUM THE FORUMS HAVE ARGUED ABOUT FOR FIFTEEN YEARS AND NEVER SETTLED.²

DISBOARDS & R/DISNEYCRUISE

~2-3× THE FARE

PALO \$55 · CABANA \$500+

THE CHATTER — "IS IT WORTH IT?"

The evergreen DISboards thread is "why do Disney cruises cost more?"; and the room's answer is honest: fifteen years ago it was a few hundred dollars more, now a few thousand, and "nothing concrete justifies the extra cost; it's expensive because enough people will pay it." The loyalist rebuttal is sincere — the drinks and kids' clubs others charge for are included, the service is a genuine step up, and for a certain family the frictionlessness is the product. Both sides are right, which is why the thread never closes.⁴

THE SCEPTIC — THE 85% QUESTION

The community's most cutting line is that you can get about eighty-five per cent of the Disney experience elsewhere for a fraction of the price — and the question is whether that last fifteen per cent is worth thousands a cabin. "Booking a cruise and then regretting it because it's so expensive" is a named DISboards genre, and even fan outlets now flag the upcharge creep as a slow tax on the faithful.⁴ Sail Disney because you want the Disney fifteen per cent — not because the brand told you the other eighty-five doesn't exist.

SOURCES 1 Community map — DISboards Disney Cruise Line forum + trip-report/meet sub-forums; r/DisneyCruise (newcomer-heavy); creators DCL Duo, Disney Cruise Line Blog (Scott Sanders, since 2012), DCL Fan, Disney Tourist Blog; Facebook sailing-date groups for FE/pin exchanges — disboards.com; reddit; dclduo.com; disneycruiselineblog.com; dclfan.com. 2 Fare comparison (2026, indicative starting/average per-person for comparable short sailings): Disney ~US\$1,400-1,900 (3-5 night) / ~\$1,730-2,750 (7-night); Royal Caribbean ~\$550-710; Carnival ~\$400-544 — NerdWallet; WrightWayTravel; 360Cruising. Disney ~2-3× a comparable cabin. 3 Adult dining after the June 2025 fleet-wide increase — Palo/Palo Steakhouse US\$55pp (+18% grat), Remy dinner US\$145, Enchanté US\$145; private cabanas ~US\$523 (Serenity Bay) to ~\$1,375 (Grand Family) at Lookout Cay / Castaway Cay — Disney Food Blog; MagicGuides; Cruise Mummy. 4 The "is it worth it" / "85% elsewhere" / buyer's-remorse threads; upcharge-creep coverage — DISboards ("why do Disney cruises cost more," "regretting it because it's so expensive"); Travel Market Report; WDW Magazine (summarised, attributed, not fetched live).

THE RABBIT HOLE • THE DEEP END

The New Ships, the Fish, and the Magnet Wars

Three new ships and a private island in two years; a culture of gift-exchanges and serving teams that follow you to dinner; and a 2025 flashpoint over, of all things, what you may stick on your door.

The fleet has never expanded faster: Lookout Cay at Lighthouse Point opened in June 2024, the Disney Treasure entered service that December, the Disney Destiny sailed in November 2025 with a Pirates-of-the-Caribbean pub aboard, and the Singapore-based Adventure followed in March 2026.¹ Against that growth sits the culture's connective tissue, stranger than the ships. The signature ritual is the fish extender — a numbered-pocket holder hung from the little metal fish beside each classic-ship door, into which a pre-arranged group leaves gifts cabin to cabin, a secret-Santa at sea, with etiquette wars over homemade-versus-store-bought and the practice of "pixie dusting" cabins outside your group.² Add rotational dining, where the restaurants change but your serving team follows you, plus Pirate Night and Marvel Day at Sea, and you have a holiday engineered to accrete traditions.

The flashpoint of the past year was smaller and funnier: doors. In 2025 Disney tightened stateroom decoration to the door only — no corridor walls, no tape, on pain of a US\$100 damage fee — and reminded everyone that magnets don't even stick to the wooden doors on the Dream and Fantasy.³ The community split between "it had got out of hand" and "you're killing a tradition" — the shape every one of this hobby's fights takes: a small rule, a large feeling, a forty-page thread.³ It is a subculture that turned a cruise into a folk practice, and argues hardest about the parts an outsider would never notice.

\$100

THE DAMAGE FEE FOR TAPE ON A STATEROOM DOOR UNDER 2025'S TIGHTENED DECORATION RULES — THE SMALL CLAUSE THAT TOUCHED OFF THE LOUDEST COMMUNITY

FIGHT OF THE YEAR.³

SOURCES 1 Fleet — Lookout Cay at Lighthouse Point opened 7 Jun 2024; Disney Treasure maiden voyage 21 Dec 2024; Disney Destiny maiden voyage 20 Nov 2025 ("Heroes & Villains," Pirates-inspired Cask & Cannon pub); Disney Adventure from Singapore 10 Mar 2026 — Wikipedia; Disney Cruise Line Blog; Cruise Critic. Classic Magic-class (Magic 1998, Wonder 1999) carry the original "fish" door emblem; Dream/Fantasy (2011/2012) have the AquaDuck and wooden doors. 2 Rituals — fish extenders (named for the metal fish by Magic-class doors), "pixie dusting," rotational dining (serving team rotates with guests), Pirate Night, Marvel/Star Wars Day at Sea; glossary terms (Castaway Club, Placeholder, gty rates, magical porthole) — The Points Guy; DCL Fan; DISboards; MagicGuides. 3 2025 stateroom-decoration rules — door only, no tape/adhesives (US\$100 damage fee), magnets don't adhere to Dream/Fantasy wooden doors; community split — Cruise Hive; Fox News; DISboards "door magnet policies." 4 Sceptic — "is it worth it," "85% elsewhere," buyer's-remorse threads; upcharge-creep coverage — DISboards; Travel Market Report; WDW Magazine (attributed, summarised). Next Descents recorded in the issue log.

THE LEXICON — A STARTER GLOSSARY

Castaway Club — the loyalty tiers, counted in cruises: Silver, Gold, Platinum, Pearl. **Fish extender (FE)** — the door-hung gift-exchange pocket; **pixie dusting** is gifting cabins outside your group. **Placeholder** — a US\$250 onboard deposit for 10% off a future cruise. **Gty** — a guarantee rate: a category or better, but Disney picks the room. **Magical porthole** — the virtual "window" in an inside cabin, a live exterior feed where a character occasionally drifts past.²

THE SCEPTIC — WHERE THE MAGIC MEETS THE INVOICE

The community's own confessions are the sharpest critique. The premium is, by the room's admission, unjustified by anything concrete except demand; the upcharges creep, and buyer's remorse is a named thread genre.⁴ The honest failure mode is the slow realisation, around your fourth booking, that the loyalty ladder you're climbing was built by the company you're paying — that "Pearl" is a marketing tier, not an achievement. Sail for the fifteen per cent you love; be suspicious of the machine that keeps telling you the next rung is the point.

NEXT DESCENTS — YOU PICK THE NEXT RABBIT HOLE (TAP A CHIP IN THE READER)

Headphone enthusiasts — IEMs and open-backs, the measurement-versus-ears wars, and an endgame that keeps moving.

Home espresso — the upgrade treadmill in one square metre, from a Bambino to a Linea Micra, and where it stops.

Astrophotography — the smart-telescope wave that just democratised the night sky, and the light-pollution workarounds a city dweller needs.

FITNESS · THE LOADED WALK

The Weighted Walk Is Having a Moment — With Numbers

Rucking — walking with a loaded pack — is 2026's defining longevity method, and for once the hype comes with a ratio behind it: a fraction of running's injury rate, several times a walk's training stimulus, and a strength-and-bone dose folded into a cardio session. The catch is in how fast you load the bar.

The optimiser's exercise of the year is the least technological one imaginable: put weight in a backpack and walk. Rucking has climbed the American College of Sports Medicine's trend lists, and the case for it is quantitative rather than merely fashionable. Carried at a sensible load, it runs an injury rate around three per thousand hours — against roughly seven for weightlifting and eighteen for running — while burning on the order of two to three times the calories of unloaded walking and adding a genuine strength-and-bone-loading stimulus a flat walk can't.¹ That profile — high metabolic and musculoskeletal return, low joint cost — is close to ideal for a mid-forties trainee protecting a long runway. The reference protocol floating through the longevity discourse is Peter Attia's: rucking three or four times a week, five or six kilometres, building toward a sixty-pound pack on hills, and deliberately "developing the brakes" on the descents for the eccentric leg strength that guards against falls decades out.²

The peer-reviewed literature keeps tightening the thread. Fresh 2026 work on "exercise snacks" — short, accumulated bouts of movement — links them in a national cohort to lower odds of sarcopenia and all-cause mortality, and a large UK-and-US cohort confirms that cardiorespiratory fitness holds its graded, inverse tie to mortality well into the seventies and eighties.³ A loaded walk banks both at once: a Zone 2 cardio session and a resistance session folded together, in the same forty minutes. As general wellness guidance, not medical advice, that efficiency is the whole appeal — one unglamorous habit doing the work of two.²

~3 vs 18

INJURIES PER THOUSAND HOURS FOR RUCKING VERSUS RUNNING — WITH TWO TO THREE TIMES THE CALORIE BURN OF UNLOADED WALKING, AND A STRENGTH-AND-BONE STIMULUS A FLAT WALK DOESN'T PROVIDE.¹

CARDIO + STRENGTH IN ONE

START AT 10–15% BODYWEIGHT

NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

THE CHATTER — THE LONGEVITY DESK

In the Attia-and-Huberman orbit and on r/longevity, rucking is sold as the efficient merge of Zone 2 and strength — and it has walked into the year's liveliest training argument: whether Zone 2 is uniquely special at all. A 2026 narrative review, with Brad Schoenfeld among the authors, argues that at matched volume higher-intensity work yields equal or greater mitochondrial adaptation, denting the Zone-2 dogma the podcasts built. The sober middle: the loaded walk is defensible whichever way that lands, because its benefit is as much musculoskeletal as metabolic.⁴

THE SCEPTIC — THE LOAD IS WHERE IT GOES WRONG

Keep the enthusiasm proportional to the evidence. Much of the rucking case rests on trend data and observational comparisons, not randomised trials, and load carriage carries real lumbar and shoulder risk if you ramp it too fast — the injury advantage evaporates the moment the pack is too heavy too soon. Plain unloaded walking already captures most of the mortality benefit, so the marginal gain from adding weight is exactly that, marginal, and worth having only if the loading is progressive. Start at ten to fifteen per cent of bodyweight, add slowly, and treat the sixty-pound hill march as a destination, not a starting line.¹

SOURCES 1 Rucking as a 2026 trend (ACSM / National Geographic trend lists); injury rate ~3 per 1,000 h vs ~7 (weightlifting) and ~18 (running); ~2–3× the calorie burn of unloaded walking; added strength/bone-loading stimulus — FitnessAvenue rucking-statistics compilation; trend coverage, 2026 (figures largely observational/trend data, flagged). 2 Reference protocol — Peter Attia rucks 3–4×/week, ~5–6 km, building toward ~60 lb on hills, "developing the brakes" on descents for eccentric strength — Attia via Fortune Well; The Drive summaries. 3 "Exercise snacks" linked to lower sarcopenia odds (~8–9% per unit of activity) and all-cause mortality — *Biology of Sport*, 2026 (national cohort); cardiorespiratory fitness's inverse, graded mortality link into the 70s–80s — *BES Journal*, 2026 (UK+US cohort). 4 Zone-2 debate — 2026 narrative review (authors incl. Brad Schoenfeld) arguing equal/greater mitochondrial adaptation at higher intensity, matched volume — GetHealthspan; substack summaries. General wellness information, not medical advice.

THE DIARY · THE AGENDA

What's Worth Booking

A crowded autumn to plan around: Singapore's first F1 Sprint weekend with a Padang full of pop beside it, and a Tokyo sumo basho whose good seats vanish the morning they go on sale — which is tomorrow.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

- 9–11 Oct

★ **F1 Singapore Grand Prix**

MARINA BAY · THE FIRST-EVER SG SPRINT WEEKEND; PADANG ACTS THE KILLERS, LANA DEL REY, JANET JACKSON, JJ LIN — BOOK EARLY
- 2–3 Oct

★ **The Weeknd — After Hours Til Dawn**

NATIONAL STADIUM · TWO NIGHTS W/ CREEPY NUTS; ON SALE (TICKETMASTER SG)
- 25 SEP

Post Malone

NATIONAL STADIUM · BIG ASS WORLD TOUR, W/ DON TOLIVER
- 19 SEP

Kit Chan — Atrium Live Tour

INDOOR STADIUM · HOMEGROWN DIVA; BROAD APPEAL
- 14 AUG

Galantis

ZOUK SINGAPORE · CLUB SHOW, OVER-18
- to 27 Feb

Marshmallow Laser Feast

ARTSCIENCE MUSEUM · 3 IMMERSIVE INSTALLS INCL. EVOLVER VR — FOR A CURIOUS ELEVEN-YEAR-OLD
- 17–22 Dec

BTS — sold out

NATIONAL STADIUM · FOUR NIGHTS, RESALE ONLY; WATCH FOR SCAM LISTINGS
- 8–10 Jan

Jay Chou — Carnival II

NATIONAL STADIUM (2027) · FLAG DEMAND NOW

JAPAN & THE REGION

PLAN THE FLIGHTS

- 8 AUG

★ **Aki Basho — tickets on sale**

RYŌGOKU KOKUGIKAN, TOKYO · TOURNAMENT 13–27 SEP; BOX FROM ~¥40K/4PAX, ARENA FROM ¥3,500 — GOOD SEATS GONE BY NIGHTFALL
- to 8 Oct

teamLab Borderless — new rooms

AZABUDAI HILLS, TOKYO · LIGHT SCULPTURE: FLOW; BOOK TIMED ENTRY; THE DAUGHTER WILL THANK YOU
- 18–20 Sep

Kishiwada Danjiri Matsuri

OSAKA · THE SPECTACULAR CART-PULLING FESTIVAL; A DAY-TRIP FROM KANSAI
- 19 Sep–13 Oct

Oktoberfest — LaLaport Toyosu

TOKYO · FAMILY-OK BY DAY, GERMAN DRAUGHT BY NIGHT
- 22 OCT

Jidai Matsuri

KYOTO · THE FESTIVAL OF THE AGES, A COSTUMED PROCESSION THROUGH THE OLD CAPITAL
- 22 Oct–3 Nov

Tokyo Ramen Festival

KOMAZAWA OLYMPIC PARK · 36 SHOPS, LIMITED BOWLS; KID-FRIENDLY

PLANNING NOTES

TIMING · SELL-OUTS · FAMILY

BEFORE YOU BOOK

Sumo on-sale is tomorrow (8 Aug): set up a Ticket Ōsumo account tonight — the boxes are gone within hours. **F1:** 2026 adds Singapore's first Sprint, so Saturday is a full race day now, not just qualifying — buy the weekend pass, not a single day. **Hotels:** race weekend (9–11 Oct) and the Weeknd nights (2–3 Oct) will be brutal; lock rooms now. **BTS'** four December nights stay sold out — verified resale only, and mind the scams.¹

FURTHER AFIELD — WORTH THE FLIGHT

- Jidai Matsuri + koyo** — pair Kyoto's 22 Oct procession with the first autumn colour for a single well-timed week.¹
- Kishiwada Danjiri** — 18–20 Sep, Osaka; one of Japan's most thrilling festivals, and free to watch from the street.¹
- Aki Basho weekend seats** — target 20–21 Sep for a Saturday-Sunday of sumo; the middle days are easiest to book.¹

SOURCES 1 F1 Singapore GP 9–11 Oct 2026 (first SG Sprint weekend; Padang acts incl. The Killers, Lana Del Rey, Janet Jackson, JJ Lin) — Racing News 365; Billboard. The Weeknd 2–3 Oct (w/ Creepy Nuts), Post Malone 25 Sep (w/ Don Toliver), Kit Chan 19 Sep, Galantis 14 Aug — Harper's Bazaar SG; Live Nation SG. Marshmallow Laser Feast at ArtScience Museum to 27 Feb 2027 — The Peak. BTS four National Stadium nights (17/19/20/22 Dec) sold out, resale only — Live Nation SG (continuity; caution on scam listings). Jay Chou Carnival II, National Stadium, 8–10 Jan 2027 — The Smart Local. Aki Basho tickets on sale 8 Aug (tournament 13–27 Sep; box from ~¥40k/4pax, arena from ¥3,500) — Tokyo Cheapo. teamLab Borderless new rooms to 8 Oct — teamlab.art. Kishiwada Danjiri 18–20 Sep, Oktoberfest LaLaport Toyosu 19 Sep–13 Oct, Jidai Matsuri 22 Oct, Tokyo Ramen Festival 22 Oct–3 Nov — MATCHA; Kanpai-Japan; FestInJapan. Dates verified against official/primary where possible; on-sale windows marked as advised.

THE TABLE · NEWLY OPEN

Singapore's Newest Tables

A Xiamen banquet institution's second local outlet, a young ex-Burnt Ends chef cooking Korean flavours through a woodfire, and a skybar that opened for the view first — three arrivals, and only one of them yet built to be judged on the plate.

The pedigree pick is LINKUS, the Minnan restaurant from Xiamen — where it once catered a BRICS summit banquet — which opened a second Singapore outlet at Takashimaya in August, after a queue-drawing Suntec City debut in February.¹ The cooking is refined regional Hokkien: a Fujian "Buddha Jumps Over the Wall" heavy with abalone and sea cucumber, and technique the food press has been warm on, Miss Tam Chiak and SG Food on Foot calling it "Minnan heritage meets modern elegance."¹ The dissent is the bill — a special-occasion price point that splits opinion on value. But it is the most finished of the month's three openings, and the one whose food you can already book with confidence.¹

The one to watch is Liora at Clarke Quay, where a young ex-Burnt Ends chef cooks Korean flavours through European technique — house ferments, an open woodfire hearth, a moody date-night room.² The first-look reviews are admiring (The Ranting Panda: "refined without losing its soul"), but a fortnight-old kitchen has not yet had to prove consistency, so it is honestly too new to call.² The

third arrival, Xava Skybar atop the National Gallery, opened on 1 August with a panorama over Marina Bay; the coverage sells the view and the sunset, not the dish — a scene-and-drinks draw for now rather than a food destination.³ None is halal, and only LINKUS earns a verdict this issue.

The booking calculus differs at each. LINKUS takes reservations and rewards them; check the launch-period set menus before committing to à la carte. Liora is the one to book early and go in curious, ideally on a weeknight. Xava is a walk-in-and-drink proposition — request a skyline table near sunset and let the kitchen prove itself over the coming month. Two of the three are promises; give them a fortnight, and let the diners, not the previews, tell you which kept it.²

Three arrivals, and only one of them yet built to be judged on the plate.

LINKUS · TAKASHIMAYA

LIORA · CLARKE QUAY

XAVA · ROOFTOP VIEW

THE BUZZ — MEDIA AHEAD OF THE DINERS

The pattern is the familiar one: the food media have written all three up, the diners are still catching up. LINKUS carries the most first-hand warmth; Liora is drawing "inventive, one to watch" tips without a settled consensus; Xava is riding rooftop-and-sunset coverage more than any verdict on the kitchen. Book LINKUS if the occasion fits, visit Liora early and curious, go to Xava for the view — and give the two newcomers a fortnight before you queue on faith.²

THE SCEPTIC — TOO NEW TO CALL, SAID PLAINLY

A rooftop a week old and a woodfire room a fortnight old both need service to settle before they earn a special trip; a first-look review is an impression, not a verdict. Xava for now is a bar with a view and a kitchen still finding its feet. Only LINKUS is a known quantity, and even there the question is value, not competence. Chase the novelty where the plates are unproven; save the expectations for the kitchen with a track record.³

SOURCES 1 LINKUS 临家 (Hokkien Flavour), Takashimaya Shopping Centre, Orchard — second SG outlet opened Aug 2026 (Suntec City debut Feb 2026); Minnan/Xiamen restaurant that catered a 2017 BRICS summit banquet; signature Fujian "Buddha Jumps Over the Wall," premium seafood; special-occasion pricing; reception warm — Miss Tam Chiak; SG Food on Foot; Daniel Food Diary. Not halal. 2 Liora, CQ @ Clarke Quay — contemporary Korean flavours via modern European technique, woodfire hearth; chef ex-Burnt Ends; first-look reviews admiring but early — The Ranting Panda (30 Jul 2026); SG City Guide. Too new to call on consistency. Not halal. 3 Xava Skybar, rooftop of National Gallery Singapore — opened 1 Aug 2026, all-day rooftop restaurant/lounge with Marina Bay panorama; coverage preview-led (view-and-vibe), no settled food verdict — Alvinology; National Gallery SG; Straits Times. Not halal. Buzz summarised in our own words; SG food-media/socials not fetched live this session.

THE LONG READ · THE UNDERCURRENT

Life in Four Cuts

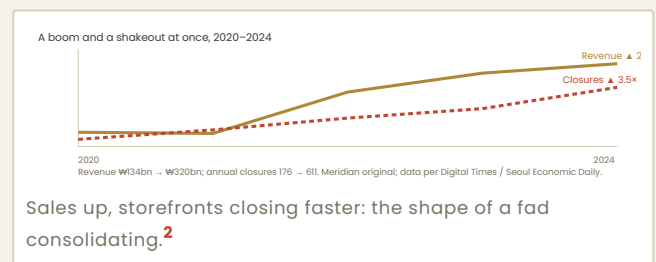
In the most camera-saturated country on earth, young Koreans queue to pay ₩4,000 for a strip of four printed photographs. It has become a US\$400-million industry — and, in the same breath, a franchise bubble bursting in plain sight. The West hasn't noticed yet.

Walk any young district in Seoul — Hongdae above all — and you pass them every few doors: bright, unmanned rooms full of photo booths, where couples and clusters of friends crowd a frame, pose for a burst of shots, choose four, and walk out with a printed strip still warm from the machine. Koreans call it *insaeng necut* — "life's four cuts" — and it has become a default ritual of a generation, the physical souvenir of a night out in a country where every one of those same people is already carrying a phone that takes a far better photograph for free.¹ That is the puzzle worth an essay. In the most camera-dense culture on the planet, the growth product of the decade is a machine that prints.

The numbers are the tell. The tax base for Korea's instant-photo-studio business climbed from about ₩134 billion in 2020 to roughly ₩320 billion in 2024 — a 2.4-fold rise in four years, pushing the sector past a US\$400-million valuation, with market researchers projecting it toward US\$1.2 billion by the early 2030s.² The category leader, Life Four Cuts, runs on the order of 410 stores and claims well over 120 million cumulative visits since 2017, around two million a month, at a base price near ₩4,000 for two strips.³ A quieter rival, Photoism, has specialised in K-pop tie-ins and was tagged a "pre-unicorn" by Korea's own SME ministry in 2025.³ And the format has begun to travel: foreign-tourist card transactions at Korean photo booths jumped about 65% year-on-year over the first seven months of 2025, as visitors treat the strip as a souvenir of Korea itself.⁴

In the most camera-dense culture on the planet, the growth product of the decade is a machine that prints.

But read the same ledger one column over and the story darkens. Over exactly the years revenue rose 2.4-fold, the number of these studios closing each year rose faster still — from 176 in 2020 to 611 in 2024, a 3.5-fold jump.² A sector can only post rising sales and rising closures at once if it is doing a specific thing: consolidating. The winners are scaling and exporting while a long tail of late entrants quietly folds — the exact signature of a fad hardening into an industry, and of a great many people discovering, one shuttered storefront at a time, that "unmanned and always open" is not the same as "profitable." Korea has seen this movie before, more than once, and the ending is the argument of the next two pages.



₩4,000

THE BASE PRICE OF A TWO-STRIP SESSION AT LIFE FOUR CUTS — PAID, SOME TWO MILLION TIMES A MONTH, FOR A PRINTED KEEPSAKE A PHONE WOULD MAKE FOR NOTHING.³

SOURCES 1 *Insaeng necut* ("life's four cuts") — Korea's unmanned self-photo-studio ritual; Hongdae as the density capital — Korea Herald ("Say 'kimchi'"); Korea Times; Seoul, 2024–26 (English-language K-culture coverage; Korean-language trade press below). 2 Instant-photo-studio revenue (tax base): ₩134.4bn (2020) → ₩133.7bn (2021) → ₩247.1bn (2022) → ₩290.6bn (2023) → ₩319.6bn (2024), ~2.4× in four years, sector ~US\$400M (2024), projected ~US\$1.2B by ~2033 (market-research estimate, directional); annual closures 176 (2020) → 611 (2024), ~3.5× — Digital Times (dt.co.kr); Seoul Economic Daily (en.sedaily.com, "Photo Booth Closures Triple as Market Overheats"). 3 Life Four Cuts (operator LK Ventures; concept acquired 2018) ~410 stores, 120M+ cumulative visits since 2017, ~2M/month, base ~₩4,000 for two strips; Photoism (Seobuk Inc.) the K-pop-collab specialist, "pre-unicorn" per the Ministry of SMEs & Startups (2025) — Seoul. 4 Foreign-tourist card transactions at photo booths +65% YoY, Jan–Jul 2025 — Korea Herald. Figures as reported in Korean and English sources; market-research valuations flagged as estimates.

Three explanations stack, and together they make the case. The first is the simplest: the physical print is reasserting itself precisely because everything else went digital. A phone photo is infinite, weightless and instantly lost in a camera roll of ten thousand; the ₩4,000 strip is scarce, tangible and curated — you choose four, and the machine commits them to paper you can hold and hand to a friend. This is the experience economy applied to memory itself. You are not buying a photograph, which you already have for free; you are buying a five-minute ritual and a keepsake, and the price is the point of the exercise, not a tax on it.¹

The second explanation is where the real money lives, and it is pure Korea: the fandom. The engine under Photoism is the idol-frame collaboration — a limited-run border featuring a specific K-pop group that turns a commodity booth into a piece of drop-mechanics merchandise. When a BTS or Stray Kids frame goes live, fans queue not to photograph themselves but to be photographed *with* their idol's branded frame, and the scarcity is engineered exactly as a sneaker release or a trading card is.² That is why the K-pop specialist, not the larger generalist, is the one venture capital calls a pre-unicorn: it has bolted the highest-margin logic in Korean culture — limited-edition fandom scarcity — onto a vending machine.

***You are not buying a photograph.
You are buying a five-minute
ritual and a keepsake — and the
price is the point.***

The third explanation is the one that should worry anyone opening a booth this year, and it is the oldest story in the Korean economy. This is a textbook franchise bubble: near-zero operating skill, unmanned around the clock, low capital to enter, and demand rented from two exogenous sources — fickle fandom cycles and an inbound-tourism surge. It is the profile of every low-barrier boom the country has run before, and Korea has run a lot of them. In 2024 the number of businesses closing in Korea passed one million for the first time in recorded

history; the photo booth is simply the newest entrant into a chronically overcrowded landscape of self-employment.³

The clearest precedent is the one every Korean already jokes about: chicken. The country supports something on the order of forty thousand fried-chicken restaurants — roughly the number of McDonald's outlets on the entire planet — with franchise chicken stores alone reaching about 31,400 in 2024, up from 25,100 six years earlier.⁴ That density was built the same way, by retirement-age entrepreneurs and the laid-off pouring severance into a low-skill franchise because the barrier to entry was a barrier to nobody, and it produced the same result: thin margins, a delivery-app squeeze, and a churn of openings and closings that never quite nets to growth. The photo booth is the chicken shop of the smartphone generation — cheaper to open, easier to automate, and heading, on the closure data, for the same shakeout.

***The photo booth is the chicken
shop of the smartphone generation
— and the closure data says it is
heading for the same reckoning.***

There is a tell in who is winning. The fortunes are not accruing to the operators who own the most rooms but to the ones who own the best collaborations — the frame partnerships with idols, the tourist-facing brand, the intellectual property a rival cannot copy overnight. That is why a mid-sized specialist can be called a pre-unicorn while a larger generalist is not, and why the money in the shakeout will flow to whoever controls the scarcity rather than whoever runs the most machines. The booth is a commodity; the frame is the asset. A generation of would-be owners is learning that distinction the hard way, one lease at a time.³

~40,000

FRIED-CHICKEN RESTAURANTS IN KOREA — ABOUT THE
NUMBER OF MCDONALD'S ON THE WHOLE PLANET — THE
LOW-BARRIER BOOM THE PHOTO BOOTH IS NOW
REPEATING.⁴

SOURCES 1 The physical-print-in-a-digital-age read; experience-economy framing — consumer-trade analysis via iConsumer ("Why hasn't *insaeng* *necut* disappeared in 10 years?"); Korea Herald; Seoul. 2 Photoism's idol-frame collaborations and drop mechanics (e.g. BTS/Stray Kids frames pulling nationwide queues); "pre-unicorn" status — Korea Times; Seoul. 3 Korean franchise-bubble profile; business closures passing 1,008,282 in 2024 (first time above one million) — Korea Times ("business closures in South Korea surpass 1 mil for first time"); Herald Economy ("an instant-photo studio every other door... closures rising amid start-up fever"). 4 Korea's ~40,000 fried-chicken restaurants (= McDonald's worldwide); franchise chicken stores ~31,397 (2024) vs 25,110 (2018) — Korea Herald; Seoul (chicken-franchise economics). Cross-market figures verified across multiple sources; historical/analogy claims below (p23) cross-checked.

There is an even closer precedent, and it is not Korean. The whole idea was invented in Japan thirty years ago. The photo-sticker booth — *purikura* — was conceived by a young designer, Sasaki Miho, and developed at the game company Atlus with Sega, launching as "Print Club" in February 1995; within a year twenty thousand machines had shipped and it was the top-grossing arcade product in Japan.¹ It boomed among schoolgirls, defined a decade of Japanese youth culture, and then — this is the part the Korean bulls skip — matured, consolidated and settled into a smaller, permanent niche. *Insaeng necut* is *purikura* re-engineered for the smartphone-and-K-pop era, and *purikura*'s arc is precisely the cool-down the closure data already hints at. The format does not vanish; it just stops being a place to open a business.

Which is the honest counter to all three of the essay's reads. The bears have a case, and it is not weak. The revenue figures rest partly on market-research aggregation rather than audited accounts, and the series is noisy — it actually dipped between 2021 and 2022 before surging — so the neat "2.4-fold" line deserves an asterisk.² The booths have no moat: an unmanned machine in a rented room is trivially copyable, which is exactly why margins compress and why so many of the 611 that closed in 2024 were late entrants who "opened to survive" and didn't. And the demand is borrowed twice over, from K-pop drop cycles and an inbound-tourism wave, both of which are exogenous and reversible — a soft idol year or a weaker won would take the froth off fast.³

WHAT THE PLATFORMS ARE SAYING

The Korean read is already ahead of the Western one. The business press frames the mood as saturation fatigue — the Herald Economy's headline translates roughly as "an instant-photo studio every other door" — and a widely-shared YouTube autopsy asks why four hundred Life Four Cuts stores "vanished in an instant," pinning it on the roughly ₩100 million it can cost to open one. Sisa Journal has run an exposé on operator realities and customer complaints. This is a country talking openly about its own bubble while the format is still being written up abroad as a charming Seoul travel tip.⁴

So what does it mean? Two things at once, and the tension between them is the point. As a business, *insaeng necut* is a bubble consolidating on schedule, and the smart money is not in opening the four-hundred-and-twelfth booth. As a cultural signal, it is something more durable: proof that even a generation raised inside an infinite, free image-stream will pay a premium — real money, for a thing the phone gives away — to make a memory scarce, physical and shared. Oscar Wilde's cynic knew the price of everything and the value of nothing; the young Koreans queuing in Hongdae have the calculation the other way round. They know a phone photo is worth nothing precisely because it costs nothing, and that four printed cuts, warm from a machine, are worth ₩4,000 for exactly the same reason.⁵

That instinct is the export, and it is why this is worth telling before the West catches up. Korea has already productised the keepsake and begun franchising it across Asia, the way it exported its pop, its skincare and its fried chicken — taking a small, human wish and turning it into a category. The booths themselves will thin out; the closure count says so. But the thing they proved — that scarcity is a feature you can sell back to people drowning in abundance — is the durable idea underneath the fad. When the FT writes this up in three weeks, that will be the line it lands on. It is on this page first.

SOURCES 1 *Purikura* — conceived by Sasaki Miho, developed at Atlus with Sega, launched as "Print Club," Feb 1995; ~20,000 machines shipped by 1996; top-grossing arcade product in Japan that year — Wikipedia (Print Club / Sparkle Snapshots); TokyoScope ("Purikura at 30"). Historical claims cross-checked. 2 Revenue series' softness (market-research aggregation; a 2021–2022 dip before the surge) — Digital Times; Seoul Economic Daily (see p21). 3 No-moat/borrowed-demand critique; "opened to survive" late-entrant closures — Herald Economy; en.sedaily.com. 4 Platform/press mood — Herald Economy ("한 집 건너 즉석사진관," roughly "a photo studio every other door"); a widely-shared YouTube explainer on ~400 Life Four Cuts closures (~₩100M to open one); Sisa Journal exposé ("인생 네 컷에 불만 찍혔다") — attributed as reported, summarised in our own words, not fetched live. 5 Oscar Wilde, *Lady Windermere's Fan* (1892) — the cynic "who knows the price of everything and the value of nothing" (this issue's From the Desk, p2). Cross-market analogy (Instax/Polaroid/vinyl revivals) per general reporting.

THE LAST WORD

Every price in this issue is easy to read; the value is the hard part. A toll, a fare, a record, a strip of four photographs — the number is printed on the front of each, and the question the whole book keeps asking is the one Wilde's cynic never bothers with: what is it actually worth? We can't answer that for you. We can only put the price and the fine print side by side, footnote both, and hold the ones we couldn't verify rather than pretend. The value is yours to set. That, too, is the small print — and the part we'd rather you weighed for yourself.

THIS ISSUE'S DESKS

The World · Singapore · Property · Technology · The Kit · The Good Life · Screen & Sound · The Family Desk · The Macro Desk ·
The Rabbit Hole · Fitness · The Diary · The Long Read

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

No. 65 · 7 Aug 2026 · Singapore

Twelve Desks · One World — sources verified; unverifiable figures held, not invented. Not investment, medical or legal advice.